



Hum101 Midterm Paper

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Myth, Power, and Practice: How Ancient Stories Shaped Politics, Culture, and Faith

Myth is a shared story people treat as true enough to live by. In the ancient world these stories shaped how communities pictured the gods, who should hold office, what counted as a good life, and even the yearly rhythm of work and worship. Myths did not decorate culture; they carried reasons for authority, assigned duties, and gave moral feelings a shape. Myth functioned as the working language of social order: it legitimated political hierarchies and social norms, it reflected and trained everyday practices, it framed religious and philosophical thinking, and it was repeatedly repurposed by rulers to fuse sacred prestige to power (Eliade, 1979; Black, 2016). The purpose of this essay is to demonstrate how myth legitimized political power, reflected cultural practices, shaped religious and philosophical discourses, and was strategically appropriated by rulers to consolidate authority. This essay will explore these functions through ancient mythologies, showing how they reinforced social hierarchies and still resonate in modern political and cultural practices.

Myths in ancient societies were central to justifying political power and social hierarchies, establishing who should rule and the structure of governance. Greek tradition is a direct case. Zeus stands as a supreme law-giver whose command and justice travel together; that image supports concentrated authority and the belief that power and right belong in the same hand (Black, 2016). Inside the polis this mapped onto citizenship ideals: the “proper” citizen was the armed, property holding male whose courage guarded the city and therefore earned a voice. Athenian democracy, though innovative, rested on that narrow ideal: adult male citizens spoke and voted; women, enslaved people, and metics did not. Heroic profiles in myth made the restricted franchise feel normal rather than chosen. Rome turns the same key differently. The tale of Romulus and Remus ties the city to Mars; sovereignty looks inherited from a war god, while the fratricide is read as tragic necessity for the common good. Later discipline, strong magistrates, and expansion could be narrated as fidelity to a sacred beginning (Mondi, 1980; Black, 2016). The way many states mythologize “founders” or wartime leaders still shapes who gets treated as a full political voice. I think that heroic filter can narrow public debate, unless we name it and widen the circle intentionally.

Myths also mirrored and trained socio-political and cultural practices so that ordinary administration felt like moral action. In Egypt the Osiris–Isis–Horus cycle casts the pharaoh as the restorer of *ma'at*, the balance that keeps chaos back. Courts, field measurements, and temple calendars became ways of performing that balance; judging a dispute or timing a tax harvest could be presented as pushing back disorder (Goebs & Baines, 2018). Public festivals and Sed jubilees linked Nile time to political time so people repeatedly felt the world set right through royal ritual (Eliade, 1979; Goebs & Baines, 2018). India offers a parallel by a different logic. In the *Mahābhārata*, dharma binds role-duty to the health of the cosmos. Householders, warriors, and rulers carry distinct obligations; keeping them is not only social order, it is moral hygiene. Marriage rules, food practice, charity, and loyalty to station stabilize hierarchy without constant force, because the ordinary act feels heavy with meaning (Deliège, 1993). Greek civic life shows the same stitch from another angle: household cults and civic festivals taught that honoring family and honoring the city were the same habit, which made law feel like piety in motion.

(Black, 2016). National holidays, school pledges, and even budget rituals still “teach” citizens what feels right. I think when policy is wrapped in ceremony, people comply more willingly so we should ask whose values that ceremony is quietly installing.

Religious narratives and philosophical discourses were shaped and conditioned by myth because stories are how complex ideas travel. Plato criticizes the poets, yet he uses myth-like scenes to carry arguments into common memory. As Edelstein (1949, p. 2). puts it, “Every reader of Plato’s works... must be aware... [he] is also an adept of myth” The Allegory of the Cave stages false seeing, painful education, and a duty to govern once truth is grasped; it teaches that rulers should be those who know more and also that they must return to serve the city, even if it costs them (Annas, 1982). Elsewhere, the so-called noble lie or “myth of metals” retells class differentiation as a birth story about gold, silver, and bronze souls; that turns a dry doctrine about division of labor into a tale a citizen can remember and teach (Edelstein, 1949). Greek heroic narratives supplied a shared vocabulary for ethics, too. The labors of Heracles became ready images for courage, perseverance, and the taming of force for public good; philosophers refined those virtues, but story made the lesson stick in everyday talk (Black, 2016). Our ethics still ride on story from superhero films to national narratives about merit. I think we should choose those stories carefully, because the images we love become the duties we live.

Rulers actively appropriated myths to consolidate their political power, using them to align their authority with divine or cosmic order. Elites also appropriated myths on purpose to join sacred value to their own projects. In Mesopotamia, Marduk’s ascent is written so that political supremacy looks like cosmic victory: he “obtained supreme power and reorganized the universe to his plans” (Lambert, 1984, p. 6). When such tales were performed in New Year rites, royal authority was tied to creation itself, so supporting the king meant siding with the god who ordered the world. In the Norse sphere, the promise of Valhalla and the Valkyries’ choice of the slain sacralized courage: “the Valkyries would fly over the fighting and select the most valiant of those who died,” then carry them to Odin’s hall (Bensel, 2008, p. 2). That belief turned death in battle into a reward economy leaders could convert into cohesion and warmaking. Early China shows a related move with a moral tone. If the ruler deviated from the proper pattern, it might be “necessary for his mandate to be taken away and for another to be appointed by Heaven to take his place” (Smith, 1957, p. 34). Here obedience and cosmic order were braided together; disaster could even be read as a signal to change dynasties. Whenever leaders frame new policies as “restoring order” after crisis, I think we should check which myth is being curated and whose costs are being glossed over.

In conclusion, myth in antiquity made rank and rule feel natural by tying them to divine order; it shaped and trained everyday practice so that law and ritual felt like one action; it gave religious and philosophical ideas forms people could remember; and it was curated by rulers to weld sacred prestige to the state. My view is that once we see myth working this way we can admire the beauty of the stories, but also resist the slide from meaning to blind obedience. That’s the balance I’m arguing for.

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